Justin F. Willett, Ph.D., M.H.A.

Associate Teaching Professor, Master of Health Administration Program
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Academic Appointments

- **Associate Teaching Professor**, Master of Health Administration Program, Department of Health Sciences, College of Health Sciences, University of Missouri, July 2026–present
- **Adjunct Instructor**, Master of Health Administration Program, Department of Health Sciences, College of Health Sciences, University of Missouri, Fall 2024 and Fall 2025

Education

- **Ph.D., Journalism** (2025) — Area of study: Strategic Communication. University of Missouri School of Journalism, Columbia, Missouri
    - **Willett, J. F.** (2025). *Content-conditional effects in patient story advertising: A dual-mechanism approach to healthcare narrative persuasion* [Doctoral dissertation, University of Missouri]. MOspace Institutional Repository. https://doi.org/10.32469/10355/110117
- **Master of Health Administration (M.H.A.)** (2021) — University of Missouri School of Medicine, Columbia, Missouri
    - Selected coursework: HLTH_ADM 7544 Managerial Epidemiology; HLTH_ADM 8470 Strategic Planning and Marketing for Health Care Organizations; HLTH_ADM 8450 Methods of Health Services Research; HLTH_ADM 7524 Health Economics; HLTH_ADM 8472 Financial Management for Health Care Organizations; HLTH_ADM 8573 Decision Making for Health Care Organizations; HLTH_ADM 8571 Decision Support in Health Care Systems
- **Bachelor of Journalism (B.J.)** (2001) — University of Missouri School of Journalism, Columbia, Missouri

Teaching

Courses Taught

- **Instructor of Record, Fall 2026** — HLTH_ADM 7544 Managerial Epidemiology: Population Health Management. College of Health Sciences, University of Missouri.
    - Required M.H.A. course applying population-health and epidemiological evidence to health-care planning, performance measurement, finance, and leadership; topics include study design, critical appraisal, bias and confounding, and interpretation of quantitative evidence.

- **Instructor of Record, Fall 2024–present** — HLTH_ADM 8470 Strategic Planning and Marketing for Health Care Organizations. College of Health Sciences, University of Missouri.
    - Required M.H.A. course covering strategic analysis, competitive positioning, market segmentation, health-care marketing, implementation, and performance measurement.
- **Instructor of Record, Spring 2023–Spring 2026** — JOURN 4242 Strategic Communication Leadership. School of Journalism, University of Missouri.
    - Elective writing-intensive course open to University of Missouri upper-level undergraduate and graduate students develops practical leadership capabilities through weekly case study analysis, peer collaboration, and real-world application.
- **Teaching Assistant, Spring 2022** — JOURN 4242 Strategic Communication Leadership. School of Journalism, University of Missouri.
- **Instructor of Record, Spring 2017** — JOURN 2100 News Writing. School of Journalism, University of Missouri.
    - Required writing-intensive course for Missouri School of Journalism students.

Certifications

- **Online Teaching Certification** — completed May 2023, Missouri Online, University of Missouri. Training in online teaching strategies, including Canvas design, teaching presence, and motivating online learning communities.
- **Certificate in Inclusive Teaching** — completed April 2023, Teaching for Learning Center, University of Missouri. Training on equity-focused teaching strategies and the planning and implementation of a strategy in the classroom.
- **Faculty Writing Intensive Certification** — completed August 2022, Campus Writing Program, University of Missouri. Training on designing writing assignments, providing feedback on writing, assessing writing assignments, and the use of revision and peer review in the writing process.

Research

Expertise

- Leadership communication
- Organizational communication
- Health communication
- Strategic communication
- Narrative persuasion and patient storytelling

Research Methods

- Quantitative experimental research, including randomized factorial designs, control conditions, power analysis, survey measurement, reliability assessment, and data-quality screening
- Structural equation modeling, regression, mediation and interaction analysis, and model-fit evaluation in R
- Quantitative content analysis

Dissertation

- **Willett, J. F.** (2025). *Content-conditional effects in patient story advertising: A dual-mechanism approach to healthcare narrative persuasion* [Doctoral dissertation, University of Missouri]. MOspace Institutional Repository. https://doi.org/10.32469/10355/110117
    - Designed and analyzed two randomized between-subjects online experiments (Study 1 N = 1,498; Study 2 N = 1,058) testing how content, character, and plot structure in patient stories influence health care consumers' perceptions and decision making. Study 1 used a seven-condition design (3 × 2 factorial plus no-message control) with a separate pretest (n = 210).
    - Methods included a priori power analysis, controlled stimulus development and pretesting, multi-item measurement and reliability assessment, data-quality screening, structural equation modeling in R, regression, mediation and interaction analysis, and model-fit evaluation.

Peer-Reviewed Journal Articles

- **Willett, J. F.**, Shin, H., Houston, J. B., & Duffy, M. (2026). Leadership communication beyond relational mediation: Proposing the Leadership Communication Process Model. *International Journal of Business Communication.* Advance online publication. https://doi.org/10.1177/23294884261479726
- **Willett, J. F.**, LaGree, D., Shin, H., Houston, J. B., & Duffy, M. (2026). The role of leader communication in fostering respectful workplace culture and increasing employee engagement and well-being. *International Journal of Business Communication, 63*(2), 361–385. https://doi.org/10.1177/23294884231195614
    - *Published as advance online publication in 2023.*
- **Willett, J. F.**, LaGree, D., Warner, B. R., Houston, J. B., & Duffy, M. (2024). Flourishing with flexibility: Leader communicative support of flexible work arrangements (FWA) enhances employee engagement and well-being. *International Journal of Business Communication.* Advance online publication. https://doi.org/10.1177/23294884241291531

- **Willett, J. F.**, Rodgers, S., & Stemmle, J. (2024). Seeking the public health angle in Missouri newspaper coverage of the opioid crisis. *Newspaper Research Journal, 45*(3), 311–331. https://doi.org/10.1177/07395329241255158
- Zhang, W., Tsou, T. H., Rodgers, S., & **Willett, J. F.** (2024). Comparing personalization strategies in social network advertising: The role of impression motivation in persuasion outcomes. *Journal of Interactive Advertising, 24*(3), 247–264. https://doi.org/10.1080/15252019.2024.2337057

Book Chapters

- **Willett, J. F.**, & Houston, J. B. (in press). The Crisis Leadership Framework: A meta-theoretical integration. In D. D. Sellnow, R. Freihaut, Y. Xu, & T. L. Sellnow (Eds.), *Encyclopedia of Crisis Management*. Edward Elgar Publishing.

Refereed Conference Papers

- **Willett, J. F.** (2024, August 8–11). *The role of patient stories in health care brand storytelling* [Poster session]. Association for Education in Journalism and Mass Communication 2024 Conference, Philadelphia, Pennsylvania, United States.
- **Willett, J. F.**, LaGree, D., Warner, B. R., Houston, J. B., & Duffy, M. (2024, June 20–25). *Flourishing with flexibility: Leader communicative support of flexible work arrangements (FWA) enhances employee engagement and well-being* [High-density session]. International Communication Association 2024 Conference, Gold Coast, Queensland, Australia.
- **Willett, J. F.**, Rodgers, S., & Stemmle, J. (2023, August 7–10). *Seeking the public health angle in Missouri newspaper coverage of the opioid crisis* [Poster session]. Association for Education in Journalism and Mass Communication 2023 Conference, Washington, D.C., United States.
- **Willett, J. F.**, LaGree, D., Houston, J. B., Shin, H., & Duffy, M. (2023, May 25–29). *The role of leader communication in fostering respectful workplace culture and increasing employee engagement and well-being* [Paper presentation]. International Communication Association 2023 Conference, Toronto, Ontario, Canada.

Service

Service to the Discipline

Reviewer

- Ad hoc reviewer, *Journal of Advertising*, 2026.
- Ad hoc reviewer, *Administrative Sciences*, 2025.
- Ad hoc reviewer, *Behavioral Sciences*, 2025.
- Ad hoc reviewer, *Humanities and Social Sciences Communications*, 2025.

- Student & Junior Faculty Reviewer Training (SRT) Program, *Journal of Advertising*, 2023–24. Review scholarship submitted to the journal under the supervision of Dr. Shelly Rodgers, former Editor-in-Chief of *Journal of Advertising*.
- Conference paper reviewer, American Academy of Advertising Conference, 2023.
- Conference paper reviewer, Association for Education in Journalism and Mass Communication Conference (Advertising Division and ComSHER Division), 2023.

Association Service

- Lead, AI Student Perspective Research Group, Graduate Education in Health Management Leadership Excellence Networks (GEHM-LENS), July 2026–present.
    - Selected to lead a multi-institution research collaboration examining graduate student perceptions of generative artificial intelligence, with participating faculty from leading MHA programs across the country. Responsibilities include research design and coordination, meeting facilitation, and multi-site study logistics.
- Member, Communication Committee, American Academy of Advertising, 2023–25.
- Presenter, Graduate Student Symposium, American Academy of Advertising, 2024.

Association Memberships

Current

- Graduate Education in Health Management Leadership Excellence Networks (GEHM-LENS)
- Association of University Programs in Health Administration (AUPHA)
- International Communication Association (ICA)

Past

- Association for Education in Journalism and Mass Communication (AEJMC)
- American Academy of Advertising (AAA)

Service to the University

- Research Fellow, Gregory Scholars Program, Missouri School of Journalism, Fall 2022–25. Work under Dr. Shelly Rodgers, Maxine Wilson Gregory Chair in Journalism Research, to mentor undergraduate and master's students in strategic communication research for positive social change.

Service to the Department

- Member, MHA Accreditation Committee, Department of Health Sciences, University of Missouri, 2026–present.
    - Co-lead for the competency standard (Standard 2) in the program's CAHME re-accreditation self-study.

- Member, MHA Admissions Committee, Department of Health Sciences, University of Missouri, 2026–present.
- Member, MHA Curriculum Committee, Department of Health Sciences, University of Missouri, 2026–present.

Professional Development

- **Mentoring at Mizzou (M@M) Workshop**, Office of the Provost and Graduate School, University of Missouri, August 19, 2026, Columbia, Missouri.
    - Full-day faculty mentor training using the Entering Mentoring curriculum from the Center for the Improvement of Mentored Experiences in Research (CIMER); interactive sessions covering core mentoring competencies such as aligning expectations, maintaining effective communication, and fostering independence.
- **CHS Show Me AI Training**, College of Health Sciences, University of Missouri, August 17, 2026, 104 Clark Hall, Columbia, Missouri.
    - In-person faculty training on Show Me AI, the University of Missouri's generative AI tool, covering navigation, teaching functions, and faculty use cases.
- **Show-Me AI Fall Prep Training Workshop**, University of Missouri, July 14, 2026, virtual.
    - Hands-on workshop on Show-Me AI, the University of Missouri's generative AI tool, covering Classroom Groups, fall course implementation, and managing AI use in class. Facilitated by Justin Palozola.
- **CAHME 2026 Annual Programs Update**, Commission on Accreditation of Healthcare Management Education, July 8, 2026, virtual.
- **AI Assessment and Assignment Redesign Lab**, Teaching for Learning Center, University of Missouri, June 3–4, 2026, Columbia, Missouri.
    - Two-day, in-person lab on redesigning course assignments and assessments for generative artificial intelligence, working from participants' own syllabi, assignment instructions, and rubrics.
- **CAHME 2026 Standards Training**, Commission on Accreditation of Healthcare Management Education, May 28–29, 2026, virtual.
- **2nd Annual CHS AI Showcase**, Teaching Excellence with Artificial Intelligence (TEA) Task Force, College of Health Sciences, University of Missouri, May 18, 2026, 105 Clark Hall, Columbia, Missouri.
    - Featured presentation: "Critical Thinking Alongside AI: Reframing Competencies for the Future Health Care Workforce," with student perspectives and interactive breakout sessions on AI in teaching and administration.
- **Introduction to the Scholarship of Teaching and Learning (SoTL) Workshop**, College of Health Sciences, University of Missouri, April 17, 2026, virtual.

- Three-hour workshop on SoTL foundations and principles of good practice, including development of a personal SoTL project plan.

Awards and Honors

- **2025 Top Dissertation Award** — Missouri School of Journalism, University of Missouri.
  - Awarded for Content-conditional effects in patient story advertising: A dual-mechanism approach to healthcare narrative persuasion.
- **2021 Bonnie and Douglas Wakefield Award** — Department of Health Management and Informatics, University of Missouri School of Medicine.
  - Given to a master's student annually to recognize significant achievement and leadership outside the classroom.
  - Presented for achievements leading COVID-19 communication for University of Missouri Health Care.

Professional Experience

Strategic Communication

Program/Research Director, February 2022–June 2026
Novak Leadership Institute, School of Journalism, University of Missouri, Columbia, Missouri

- Directed the institute's leadership communication research agenda, producing peer-reviewed publications on leadership communication, employee engagement, and well-being. Contributed to leadership development programming and promotion. Led website strategy and operations, strategic communication strategy, and writing and editing.

Communications Manager, February 2018–January 2022
University of Missouri Health Care / School of Medicine, University of Missouri, Columbia, Missouri

- Managed a 6-person team responsible for promoting MU Health Care and the School of Medicine through content, social media, and websites (muhealth.org and medicine.missouri.edu). Managed a $900,000 annual budget. Collaborated with leaders across the health system and university.
- Public information section leader for MU Health Care COVID-19 Incident Command. Helped lead MU Health Care's COVID-19 communication efforts, including promotion of the health system's COVID-19 vaccine program. The health system's evidence-based COVID-19 vaccine content garnered millions of pageviews and boosted total pageviews of muhealth.org owned content by nearly 1200% in 2021 (13 times higher than 2020).
- Responsibilities: Website design and strategy; patient story advertising; social media strategy and planning; digital and print publications; content marketing; writing and editing.

Communication Strategist, July 2015–February 2018
University of Missouri Health Care / School of Medicine, University of Missouri, Columbia, Missouri

- Individual contributor working on web development, content creation, patient story advertising, and social media strategy and planning.
- Led the redesign of the muhealth.org (2017) and medicine.missouri.edu (2018) websites.

Editor, November 2014–July 2015
Influence & Co., Columbia, Missouri

- Content marketing strategy, writing, and editing for clients in a variety of industries.

Journalism

Associate City Editor, April 2010–November 2014
Columbia Daily Tribune, Columbia, Missouri

- Planned news coverage for print and web editions, edited local news stories, posted content to the website, and helped manage the website and moderate online comments.

Business Editor, September 2007–November 2014
Columbia Daily Tribune, Columbia, Missouri

- Wrote, assigned, and edited business stories for the Tribune's daily print publication and for the award-winning Saturday Business section. Worked with local business professionals who generated contributed content for the Saturday Business opinion page.

Assistant Editor, May 2006–September 2007
Military Reporter, December 2003–May 2006
Fayetteville Observer, Fayetteville, North Carolina

- Supervised copy editors and oversaw production of the daily newspaper. Served as editor-in-charge on nights and weekends.
- Served as a military beat reporter covering the 82nd Airborne Division, Special Forces, and other units at Fort Bragg and Pope Air Force Base. Traveled to Iraq in 2004 with the North Carolina National Guard.

Computer-assisted reporting intern, June 2003–August 2003
Miami Herald, Miami, Florida

- Worked on computer-assisted reporting projects and wrote a variety of daily stories for the Miami Herald and its zoned editions.

Reporter, May 2001–May 2003
Columbia Daily Tribune, Columbia, Missouri

- Covered a variety of beats, including city government and crime and courts.